Of Loss and Grieving

(A Collection)

By Mary Oliver

I Want to Write Something So Simply

I want to write something
so simply
about love
or about pain
that even
as you are reading
you feel it
and as you read
you keep feeling it
and though it be my story
it will be common,
though it be singular
it will be known to you
so that by the end
you will think—
no, you will realize—

4NG Fanatics

that it was all the while
yourself arranging the words,
that it was all the time
words that you yourself,
out of your heart
had been saying.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: Evidence: Poems
ISBN: 978-0807068984
Publisher: Beacon Press
Date (Month/Year): 2009

INTRODUCTION

As a poet, Mary Oliver is an excellent antidote for the excesses of civilization. She is a poet of wisdom and generosity whose vision allows us to look intimately at a world not of our making. She speaks simply so that all can hear and her ruminations about death and grief whisper quietly to all of us who have experienced any type of loss. This is a collection of her most touching poetry. This collection is entitled “Of Loss and Grieving” by Mary Oliver

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

When Death Comes

When death comes
like the hungry bear in autumn;
when death comes and takes all the bright coins from
his purse

to buy me, and snaps the purse shut;
when death comes
like the measle-pox

when death comes
like an iceberg between the shoulder blades,

I want to step through the door full of curiosity,
wondering:
what is it going to be like, that cottage of darkness?

And therefore I look upon everything
as a brotherhood and a sisterhood,
and I look upon time as no more than an idea,
and I consider eternity as another possibility,

4NG Fanatics

and I think of each life as a flower, as common
as a field daisy, and as singular,

and each name a comfortable music in the mouth,
tending, as all music does, toward silence,

and each body a lion of courage, and something
precious to the earth.

When it's over, I want to say all my life
I was a bride married to amazement.
I was the bridegroom, taking the world into my arms.

When it's over, I don't want to wonder
if I have made of my life something particular, and real.

I don't want to find myself sighing and frightened,
or full of argument.

I don't want to end up simply having visited this world

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: Evidence: Poems New and Selected Poems, Volume One
ISBN: 978-0807068779
Publisher: Beacon Press
Date (Month/Year): April 15, 2004

TRANSITION

The next poem in this collection follows Oliver on a visit to a hospital that dates back to before the Civil war and contemplates the timelessness of loss across the decades.

University Hospital, Boston

The trees on the hospital lawn
are lush and thriving. They too
are getting the best of care,
like you, and the anonymous many,
in the clean rooms high above this city,
where day and night the doctors keep
arriving, where intricate machines
chart with cool devotion
the murmur of the blood,

4NG Fanatics

the slow patching-up of bone,
the despair of the mind.
When I come to visit and we walk out
into the light of a summer day,
we sit under the trees —
buckeyes, a sycamore and one
black walnut brooding
high over a hedge of lilacs
as old as the red-brick building
behind them, the original
hospital built before the Civil War.
We sit on the lawn together, holding hands
while you tell me: you are better.
How many young men, I wonder,
came here, wheeled on cots off the slow trains
from the red and hideous battlefields
to lie all summer in the small and stuffy chambers
while doctors did what they could, longing
for tools still unimagined, medicines still unfound,
wisdoms still unguessed at, and how many died
staring at the leaves of the trees, blind

to the terrible effort around them to keep them alive?
I look into your eyes
which are sometimes green and sometimes gray,
and sometimes full of humor, but often not,
and tell myself, you are better,
because my life without you would be
a place of parched and broken trees.
Later, walking the corridors down to the street,
I turn and step inside an empty room.
Yesterday someone was here with a gasping face.
Now the bed is made all new,
the machines have been rolled away. The silence
continues, deep and neutral,
as I stand there, loving you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: American Primitive
ISBN: 978-0316650045
Publisher: Back Bay Books
Date (Month/Year): April 1983

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

TRANSITION

And if love . . . . no not love . . . . sorrow could be personified, this is what she would be.

Love Sorrow

Love sorrow. She is yours now, and you must
take care of what has been
given. Brush her hair, help her
into her little coat, hold her hand,
especially when crossing a street. For, think,

what if you should lose her? Then you would be
sorrow yourself; her drawn face, her sleeplessness
would be yours. Take care, touch
her forehead that she feel herself not so

utterly alone. And smile, that she does not
altogether forget the world before the lesson.
Have patience in abundance. And do not
ever lie or ever leave her even for a moment

by herself, which is to say, possibly, again,
abandoned. She is strange, mute, difficult,

sometimes unmanageable but, remember, she is a child.

And amazing things can happen. And you may see,

as the two of you go

walking together in the morning light, how

little by little she relaxes; she looks about her;

she begins to grow.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: Red Bird
ISBN: 978-0807068939
Publisher: Beacon Press
Date (Month/Year): April 1, 2009

TRANSITION

And as sorrow grows, Oliver believe there are three important thing that you must be able to do: love, hold on and let go . . .

In Blackwater Woods

Look, the trees

are turning

4NG Fanatics

their own bodies

into pillars

of light,

are giving off the rich

fragrance of cinnamon

and fulfillment,

the long tapers

of cattails

are bursting and floating away over

the blue shoulders

of the ponds,

and every pond,

no matter what its

name is, is

nameless now.

Every year

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

everything
I have ever learned

in my lifetime
leads back to this: the fires
and the black river of loss
whose other side

is salvation,
whose meaning
none of us will ever know.
To live in this world

you must be able
to do three things:
to love what is mortal;
to hold it

against your bones knowing
your own life depends on it;

4NG Fanatics

and, when the time comes to let it go,
to let it go.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: American Primitive
ISBN: 978-0316650045
Publisher: Back Bay Books
Date (Month/Year): April 1983

TRANSITION

In 2012 grief and loss came even closer to home for Oliver who was diagnosed with lung cancer. "The Fourth Sign of the Zodiac" is a four-part poem that recalls the shadowy underworld of loss and survival. And yet, grief is coupled with a hopefulness. The poem is petitionary, asking of us to make what we can of the time we have left.

The Fourth Sign of the Zodiac

1.

Why should I have been surprised?
Hunters walk the forest
without a sound.
The hunter, strapped to his rifle,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the fox on his feet of silk,
the serpent on his empire of muscles—
all move in a stillness,
hungry, careful, intent.
Just as the cancer
entered the forest of my body,
without a sound.

2.

The question is,
what will it be like
after the last day?
Will I float
into the sky
or will I fray
within the earth or a river—
remembering nothing?
How desperate I would be
if I couldn't remember
the sun rising, if I couldn't
remember trees, rivers; if I couldn't

4NG Fanatics

even remember, beloved,
your beloved name.

3.

I know, you never intended to be in this world.
But you're in it all the same.

so why not get started immediately.

I mean, belonging to it.
There is so much to admire, to weep over.

And to write music or poems about.

Bless the feet that take you to and fro.
Bless the eyes and the listening ears.
Bless the tongue, the marvel of taste.
Bless touching.

You could live a hundred years, it's happened.
Or not.
I am speaking from the fortunate platform
of many years,
none of which, I think, I ever wasted.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Do you need a prod?

Do you need a little darkness to get you going?

Let me be urgent as a knife, then,

and remind you of Keats,

so single of purpose and thinking, for a while,

he had a lifetime.

4.

Late yesterday afternoon, in the heat,

all the fragile blue flowers in bloom

in the shrubs in the yard next door had

tumbled from the shrubs and lay

wrinkled and fading in the grass. But

this morning the shrubs were full of

the blue flowers again. There wasn't

a single one on the grass. How, I

wondered, did they roll back up to

the branches, that fiercely wanting,

as we all do, just a little more of

life?

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Book: Blue Horses
ISBN: 978-1594204791
Publisher: Penguin Press
Date (Month/Year): October 14, 2014

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY